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Steve Buckingham — Part II

In Part Two of our interview, Steve Buckingham talks about his work with Dolly Parton, and the "Spirituals to Swing" re-issue project. He also addresses the importance of music in the Civil Rights movement.

Steve was interviewed in Clinton, New York on September 24, 2019 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: So Mr. Buckingham, welcome back to Hamilton College.

SB: Thanks, Monk.

MR: You just caused a fire drill. But I was very interested in some of the things you were talking about in the country music class, and it made me think of — we posted your Part 1 interview.

SB: I've seen it. She found it.

MR: And it had some nice comments. One person did say "No Dolly Parton?" We didn't talk about Dolly.

SB: I don't think that — going to the jazz archive.

MR: Well that's okay. It's all music, right?

SB: Well like Duke Ellington said, there's good music and bad music. That's basically it.

MR: Yeah. So I did have a couple of questions about your association with her. And when you started working with her, you said '89 or so, both of you already had had success.

SB: She certainly had had a lot of success, going back to — well yeah, from the 70s on for her. And then that's when I started playing sessions. I mean the first session was really 1969 and '70. But I was a session player from '73 on. I started producing records in '77.

MR: So you both knew your business. And I wondered if you ever had any like creative control issues between the two of you.

SB: Never. No.

MR: Why not?

SB: We were on a level playing field if you want to call it that way. I mean Dolly is Dolly and she is a fountain of talent, a fountain of ideas. But she works fast and likes to work fast. I like to work fast. I would put the best musicians around her, the best engineers, the best studio. I mean if she didn't write the songs we found the best songs. And no, we never argued about anything creatively. At all. In fact there's just a few times with all the artists I've produced that, you know, by the time they got to me, even if they were new artists, I kind of showed them the ropes in the studio. I certainly didn't have to show the ropes to Dolly and a lot of the people I worked with, but there were a lot of new artists. So with the experienced artists there weren't creative differences so much. And even with the new

artists, they were trying to get their foot in the door so they're not going to argue with you.

MR: I see.

SB: But no, Dolly and I had a great chemistry. Still do. I mean we're still great friends. Like I said she was at our wedding in June.

MR: Yeah, and you said you're going to a 50th anniversary.

SB: October 12 she's having a — their 50th anniversary of the first appearance on the Opry. And she has twelve tickets. We're two of the twelve.

MR: That's great. She was so prolific, or she is so prolific, I wonder if you ever talked about where her song inspiration comes from.

SB: Well I don't want to speak for her but I've heard her say enough times she's very spiritual. She gets up very early in the morning, 3, 4 or 5 — 3 or 4 in the morning, and would always walk out and had this thing, "Hello, God." And Dolly has, all of her houses, in every room, her office, everywhere she has a place, whether it's L.A., Nashville, East Tennessee, there's a pad and a pencil and a pair of glasses, drug store glasses, in every room. You walk in there's a pad, there's a pencil, and the glasses. And in her — in her car, she doesn't drive that much. Someone's usually driving her. But there's always a pad and a pencil in any of her vehicles and then of course on her tour bus. There's a pad and a pencil and a pair of those glasses in every room. So, and the ideas are constant. If we would be taking a long drive somewhere — and it wasn't just song ideas. She'd say, "Oh I've got a great idea for a name for a line of clothes." And she'd jot it down. She'd see a restaurant and that would give her an idea for something else. So it wasn't just song titles or song ideas, it was everything. It was just constantly. And one of my engineers through all of the albums with Dolly, Gary Paczosa, said one time, he said, "You're a great editor for Dolly" because it's like a pitcher throwing you ten fastballs at once, and you've got to figure which of those fastballs am I going to catch. Because it's song ideas, songs coming at you like this, and you've got to figure out that's the one I've got to catch and put that here. Okay here's one. And then you finally end up with your ten, twelve or fourteen songs you're going to record. Because they come fast and furious, the ideas. And you, or at least I, Gary said, was a great editor to catch the ball, the right ball and put it over here.

MR: And some that you didn't pick might end up on the next record?

SB: Yeah. Or she, more than once, a song that I remember from two years ago, "Here it Comes Again" re-written. Same title but rewritten, maybe some different lyrics and maybe a different melody, a few different chords. That happened more than once.

MR: So when she sang, "What a Friend We Have in Jesus," she means it.

SB: Oh yeah. That was on her live album. Oh yeah. Yeah. I wouldn't say she is religious as much as spiritual. But oh yeah, that's heartfelt pretty much. Yeah that live album especially. Her family was there.

MR: You know country music and blues especially, sort of came from humble origins. But you never, hardly ever see a photograph of a country musician or a blues musician where they're not dressed up and looking sharp. I wonder if you have any thoughts about —

SB: I'll tell you what she says.

MR: Okay.

SB: She's always camera-ready she says. Now of course if we're sitting around in her bungalow next to her office going over songs she's not decked out. But she always said, "I'm camera ready when I step out the door because if somebody sees me, if it's the only time they ever see Dolly Parton, I want to look like what they think Dolly Parton should look." That's — I remember that specifically. And trust me, most artists are not that way. They don't — they're not that way. They're not always camera ready. She's always — if you see her in public she's camera ready. And that's what she says. "I don't want somebody to say 'I saw Dolly Parton, you wouldn't believe how bad she looked.'" She's always Dolly when she's in public.

MR: I see. And one of the — I don't know if it was a student or something asked — actually at one of the YouTube comments was how can she play guitar with those long nails. And you actually answered it.

SB: Well I'll tell you now again, when she gets serious about the songwriting, the acrylic nails come off. And she plays. I mean she's got, like I say, a great lick, like Maybelle Carter had a lick. And Dolly has a really good lick on the guitar, clawhammer banjo, dulcimer and autoharp. But the way she does it live, with the nails, and they're acrylic, and she can do the nails as a percussive instrument. That's how she wrote "9 to 5." I can't do it 'cause I can't make that noise, but she could make that noise, it sounded like a typewriter [scats]. "Stumbled out of bed." And she wrote it like that on the set, in her head, singing to herself, doing the rhythm with the acrylic nails. She can make a rhythm sound. She can actually, I've recorded that sound on something with her. But when she plays live, with the nails, it's an open tuning on her little "Baby Martin" we call it. Well of course now she's using sequin guitars and all this stuff. But it's an old "Baby Martin" we call it. Her uncle bought it for her used, I think it's a 1927 Martin. And that's what all the songs were written on that I know of. But when she plays live, and she used to take that guitar all the time and never used a strap, it was a little pink and gray cord that tied around the head stop on the knot and came around here, but it was a little gray and pink cord. And live she would always open D, open G, whatever would fit the song. But she didn't have guitar techs running back and forth with different open tunings for her, but

it's all open tunings. 'Cause if you watch her she's barring the chords. And sometimes will stick a finger in to make it a minor or a seventh or whatever. But it's all bar. It's all open tuning, usually in D.

MR: That's great.

SB: And if she has to do it in a different key just put a capo on.

MR: That's some nice behind-the-scenes info right there. So I've got three or four things I'd like to get through today. And before the cameras were rolling you actually answered one of my questions. And it was about the "Spirituals to Swing" re-issue. And I was wondering, this might sound snarky, but what made you think — my question was, what made you believe you are qualified to take on that project. But then you answered me with all the photographs you were talking about.

SB: Well I'll tell you how that all came about. I was with Columbia Records for ten, eleven, twelve years. VP of A&R. And then that was when CBS, Columbia and Epic, and I think it was around 1989 Sony bought Columbia and Epic from CBS. And I stayed on. And then — I can't remember exactly the year, I want to say '97, '96, '95, '96, Sony approached Dolly about doing her own imprint (this will lead to "Spirituals to Swing" believe it or not), her own imprint label. And she called it Blue Eye Records. So the records from then on were Blue Eye/Sony. And that lasted two years and then we went to Universal. It was Blue Eye, Sony was on Sony of course, Tommy Mottola was the president then. Then we did it with Universal with Doug Morris. But about a year into it I told Dolly I said, "I just don't think this is going to happen." Because we were supposed to submit new acts to be signed. And they weren't getting signed. And several of them went on to huge careers with other labels. So I was getting a little antsy I guess you'd say. And about that same time Larry Welk, Lawrence Welk's son, started calling me. I was most of the time in Nashville but in L.A. a lot. They were in Santa Monica. Welk Music. And he started calling me. We knew each other, because he had Welk Music Publishing in Nashville and I knew — one of my best friends ran that. So Larry started calling me and said, "You know we've got the old Vanguard label we bought and we've been just kind of doing re-issues of the old Vanguard jazz series and those things. And we wanted to kind of re-vamp — "Ramp it up" he said. And he sounds the orders, "What would you do?" I said, "Well if it was me I'd do the same thing the Solomon Brothers did in the 50s when they started it in New York." They signed artists, no matter what genre it was in — we were talking, I did a jazz class for Doc this morning and I was talking about the Solomon Brothers and starting Vanguard in the 50s in New York. Because they would sign Paul Robeson after he'd been blackballed in the red scare. And the Weavers after they had been blackballed in the red scare. And of course the jazz series, I know you're familiar with all that. It was not one genre of music on Vanguard in the 50s. If it was a

great artist, no matter what, even the political backlash in the 50s, it was Vanguard. I said I'd do the same thing the Solomon Brothers do. Just find great artists no matter what the genre and make it an artist-friendly label. And he called me and he called me and picked my brain. And I remember getting off the phone one day and I remember telling my assistant then, Jenny, I said, "I think he's going to offer me a job." And she said, "What would you do?" I said, "I would take it and you would do it with me. You'd still be my assistant." And I went up to L.A. on one of the trips and went to Santa Monica, and he did offer me the position. And by that time I had told Dolly that Larry Welk's offered me this job to do Vanguard. And I said it's like — it would open up a whole new arena for me of different types of music. Signing new artists. And she said, "Jump on it. Do it." Dolly said that to me. And then she stayed on Universal. And so I went to Vanguard, based in Santa Monica. I was back and forth once a month, to the point I had a condo in Santa Monica. I was there once a month. And right after I got there we bought Sugar Hill Records in Durham, North Carolina, which was primarily a bluegrass label. Doc Watson and Doyle Lawson and Quicksilver, and groups like that. And June of 1999 I get on a plane to go to L.A., sit down, and who walks in and gets in the seat right in front, Dolly. We just happened to get on the same plane. And I tapped her shoulder and she flipped out and made whoever was sitting next to her to change seats with me. So we sat together on the way to L.A. It was June of '99. And I said during the conversation I said, "We bought this label in Durham, North Carolina. Sugar Hill Records. Bluegrass, this and that. I said, "Would you ever consider doing a bluegrass record?" So we started talking about it on that flight and went to dinner that night in L.A. and put the whole idea together. And she said, "I've got to do a movie the rest of this month, and July, I'm open August." So I said, "I'll put it together." And we got the best musicians, bluegrass musicians. She called it God's Bluegrass Band. And we went in, in a day and a half and we cut the album. "The Grass is Blue" which won the Grammy, best bluegrass album; won the IBMA Bluegrass Music Association best bluegrass album. And then so now she was signed to Sugar Hill. Unbelievable. I had Vanguard and Sugar Hill. So things are going full circle. And the following year we did the follow-up, "Little Sparrow" won the Grammy. And like I said, we're still friends to this day. So it all came around. But while I was at Vanguard, started at Vanguard, I was wandering around in the vaults one day. And I knew they had done the "Spirituals to Swing," the old 33-1/3 LP. But I got to looking in the vault and I came across a whole shelf STS, STS. And I pull it out and it's "Spirituals to Swing." And I got chills. I get chills now thinking about it. It was originally recorded on disk when John Hammond did the concerts in 1938 and '39 at Carnegie Hall. So it was recorded on disk. They were transferred to tape in the early 50s when that album, the first "Spirituals to Swing" album came out, LP. But I found that here were the tapes that had been

transferred from the disk. And I got to looking through this stuff. And I have my own big two-track recorder, bigger than that. It was that much wider and that much taller. So I sat in my office and started listening to these tapes. And the quality was phenomenal. Tape in the 50s and even in the 60s held up much better than tape in the 70s and 80s 'cause —

MR: I've heard that.

SB: It was awful. The tape that was made in the 70s especially. When you went back it just started shredding and you'd stop. So we were literally putting them in little ovens, and we called it baking the tapes to keep them from just flaking — you know if you ran it through one time it was gone. There was all the oxide laying on the table. So one of the guys got the idea that baking them — and now they do it — it's very sophisticated. But I started listening — I was kind of skeptical when I saw those tapes and I put it on and I was sitting there waiting to see the flakes with the oxide. And it was not. And the quality was phenomenal. The recording quality and the tape had held up. So I called a friend of mine that had a studio in L.A., actually Doug Sax, the Mastering Lab who at that time was still in Hollywood. I called Doug, I said, "I'm bringing over boxes of tapes I need to get safeties made of these." Because these were the only copies of those two concerts. So once I had the copies made, because I was a little nervous like I'm saying this is it, if something goes wrong or if it breaks or stretches, this is ruined. Or God forbid if the oxide starts flaking off. So Doug made, of course he was the best mastering guy. And now I had safeties. So now I could sit in my office with the two track and listen to the stuff. And I knew over here I had the LP, which like I said you could only get about 30 minutes on an LP, both sides, total. And of course these are hours long concerts. Basie and the boogie-woogie piano players, and you know everybody is on that album. And I knew the album pretty well by memory. And I started listening and I said wait a minute, I don't remember this section. You know? And I literally started finding — because you know the Goodman band was there, the second year I believe it was. But Basie was both years. And all those great artists. And I started finding solos that had been cut out to make it all fit on this one album, a 33-1/3 LP. And you were very limited in your time back in those days. Because once it got to the inside of an album if you tried to cram too much it would just start skipping. The needle would start skipping.

MR: When they cut those solos out then they were splicing tape?

SB: Um hum. So what I was finding was the tape with the splicing, the splices. You know how they have the white splice tape of course. But they would cut right, diagonally. They were professionally edited. But on other reels I started hearing pieces of things. Or I'd hear one that was not edited. And I said I don't remember that. And I'd start listening and I'd start making — I had tablets filled with notes. And then I started finding reels with — it was spliced but you'd start playing it and it would be like a solo, a sax trading off an

electric guitar and then that would go on for a while and there would be a splice and here's another solo from a totally different song. It was just solos on these reels, spliced together. And I started listening and it doesn't take a genius to figure out that's Lester Young trading off of Charlie Christian. These things. I get chill bumps as you can imagine. So I started — I was literally, I don't know how many legal pads I filled with notes on this. And I got with Doug Sax and started constructing this stuff. By the end I had two sets of safeties made so I could keep one in Santa Monica and at Doug's place in Hollywood, and also a set that I could take back to Nashville and be working on it in one of my other studios with other mastering engineers. And it took a long time as you can imagine, to piece this together. And I still couldn't put it all in the box set. The box set is the best of the two concerts by far. Some of it was — I mean it was John Hammond with an old Victrola on the stage on a stool playing some old records. I mean this is in Carnegie Hall and they had a microphone with him playing a Victrola. Because I talked to Mr. Hammond about this at one time, before I even got the work up, because he was talking about all that stuff. So I remembered all that. But that was on the tapes but as you can imagine playing these old 78s on a Victrola on a stage at Carnegie Hall with a microphone. It was terrible, tinny and almost inaudible. But that's how he would start the concert. And I just thought well that's historically valuable. The tapes are certainly still in existence but I thought that's not going to work for the CD box set. So anyway, it was an extensive undertaking but it was a labor of love. And I did know the music. And I knew Mr. Hammond, like I was talking about. You weren't there this morning when I was talking about John Hammond. Because when I do my classes, "Rhythm & Blues Tore Down the Walls of Segregation," my first class is about John Hammond, how he talked Benny Goodman into hiring Teddy Wilson and integrated music in 1935. And Lionel Hampton and Charlie Christian. And I talk to my student about this is twelve years before Jackie Robinson and the Dodgers. And that's my whole basis of my class is music played the bigger part of integrating society than the courts or baseball or something like that. So I knew Mr. Hammond, I knew the music, and I was confident I could do it.

MR: Some of his statements in the paragraph here in the original liner notes, the music nobody knows, are quite illuminating about the time. He said, "The music of these hot musicians and their talented colleagues must first be considered as music. It is not, as ignorant people contend, a sort of anarchy in music."

SB: That sounds like him. Is that from my liner notes? Did I put that in there?

MR: It's from the original — from the box set, yeah.

SB: Well 'cause I found the original program in the New York Public Library. And it was all yellowed and I had a dust-up with our art director. Because if you notice in the set, it's got the Bessie Smith picture and it's the original program, but I had to format it to fit in

the — because you know it's this wide instead of this wide to fit in a box set. But it was all yellowed and I loved it. And I made copies in the New York Public Library. But the art director at Welk in Santa Monica got into it. Because when the artwork came back for my first approval she had taken all the yellow out of it and it was white. And I said no, no, no, no, no. I said, "That was part of the charm is the yellowed paper from all those decades." And we got into it about it. And Larry Welk backed me and I got my way about the yellowed looking program. But if you notice on the liner notes, my name's not on there. She accidentally left my name off. They called me in after everything had been done and Larry called me and said well, he showed me this and he said, "Your name is left off the liner notes." And everybody was already telling me this is going to win the Grammy for the best liner notes. But he said, "We can stop production. It's going to take us a month or two to re-do it, to get your name on it. And I said screw it. Put it out like that. But that's why my name is not on it. My name is, I'm obviously credited as the Re-release Producer. How great is that? Produced by John Hammond, Re-release Produced by Steve Buckingham. You can't beat that. One of your idols and mentors.

MR: Yeah and a piece of — you've had a big role in a piece of history. I'm wondering if the people that went to this concert and they're reading in the notes "the producers of this concert ask one indulgence from the audience. Most of the people on the program are making their first appearance before a predominantly white audience. Many of them never visited the north before. They'll do their best if the audience will cooperate by creating an atmosphere of informality and interest."

SB: At Carnegie Hall.

MR: At Carnegie Hall.

SB: Pretty heavy.

MR: It is very heavy.

SB: Yeah. And you know the story too, he couldn't get a sponsor. Do you know the story on that?

MR: I don't know that.

SB: If you look on my original program that I found, at the top you know is a drawing of Bessie Smith, who died before the concert obviously. He wanted Robert Johnson but Johnson had been killed. I mean that's just the way it was. So anyway, if you look at the program in the box set at the top it says, "The New Masses Present Spirituals to Swing." John Hammond went to everybody in New York to sponsor him for the program, to help pay for it. The NAACP turned him down because, he said, "We don't want to be associated with blues and swing music. That's a little beneath the NAACP. He went to everybody in New York. And when you look on there and it says, "The New Masses

Present," the "New Masses" was a communist newspaper in New York. And that's the only group he could get to help sponsor the first concert.

MR: I'll be darned.

SB: And of course Mr. Hammond talked about, he was such a radical, especially about desegregating everything, not just music, night clubs, the Army when he got chose for the troops. He wanted to desegregate everything. And did. And so he was labeled a radical. And because of the "New Masses" thing, he's a communist, but he didn't get caught in the red scare thing in the 50s.

MR: His family was wealthy, correct?

SB: The Vanderbilt family.

MR: Yes. So he had the sort of financial luxury of taking these causes and really getting behind them.

SB: As he said, "I had the means to pay for my" — he paid for the sessions for Basie and Billie Holiday. He paid for those things himself. He was his own bank for that stuff.

MR: There's some real gems on the thing and I was listening to the one, "Stompin' at the Savoy" with the Benny Goodman Sextet. And I hadn't looked at the personnel but I am hearing this chomp-chomp-chomp-chomp — and I go man, Freddie Green's really going at it. And then I looked and it was Charlie Christian. And that surprised me I guess because I'm not sure I had heard Charlie Christian do that. I was more familiar with his soloing.

SB: On the electric. But they could do — now I'll tell you a funny story that Sweets told me, Sweets Edison. Of course Freddie Green was the guy on the archtop acoustic rhythm. Although Chet Atkins knew everybody. He told me the best rhythm guitarist he ever heard was um — Homer and Jethro — Homer Hanes. Remember Homer and Jethro? The guitar and mandolin kind of comedy duo? He said Homer Hanes was the best of the old archtop rhythm players. Freddie Green was second. And those guys, the action on their guitars was up this high. I mean it was impossible to fret those things, but Freddie Green was the guy, man. But Sweets told me that one time Freddie Green shows up with an amplifier and a pick-up on his guitar. And you know, he said they hated this thing, because the way he went chomp-chomp-chomp you know every beat is a chord change. And so during a break Lester Young took a pair of wire cutters and went in the amp and started snipping wires. So he came back and said Freddie Green gave up on the electric guitar. That's why you never heard Freddie Green playing an electric. But you know I haven't looked at the box set in years. I've got copies at home but I think I've pointed this out, some of it was re-done in the studio and I've even got the pictures I think I put in there. I know I've got one at the house. And it's Freddie Green and Charlie Christian and Basie and Goodman, Jo Jones and you know, Lester Young, Buck Clayton. So they re-

did some things in the studio. And I talk about it in there. They'd never talked about it before but Mr. Hammond had told me. And in all my delving around and all the notes and tapes and everything I found all that stuff too. But yeah, not too bad to have Freddie Green and Charlie Christian playing, and Lester Young trading off with them. I know it's, like I say, heavy stuff.

MR: Do you think it would have been — I hesitate to say better — if those concerts had been totally miced like they would today. Would it have —

SB: It would have certainly been different. I don't think it would have been better.

MR: Yeah. That's why I wondered about better.

SB: No, this morning in the class, this jazz class this morning, I was talking about recording. And I said when I started recording it was on 4-track. These guys were doing mono of course on disk and even when tape started it was mono. And then 2-track and eventually 3-track, then 4-track. I started in '69 on 4-track, and then we'd go to Philadelphia, George Massenburg, my oldest friend in the business who is the man. He invented parametric equalization and all this stuff. We're still friends. But George and I would go from Baltimore where he had a studio, a four track, we'd go to Philadelphia, Sigma Sound, 'cause they had an eight track. And then George built his own 16-track console and got an Ampex 16-track, and then the 24-track analog, and then eventually 48-track digital, still on tape. And that was a nightmare. And I mean Scotch — 3M made the first digital 48-track I saw, but they would actually, they would tape cotton things to clean the tape every time it came around. And they were notorious for fire spitting out of the back of the first 48-track machines. But then it went to digital digital. But I said, like I told the students today, now you've got on your computer if you want to use 200 tracks you can, I said, but it doesn't make the music better. I said the Beatles records were on 4-track. Anyway, the point is if they had had individual mics like we do now for the "Spirituals to Swing" concerts, I don't think it would have been better. It would have been different. But you know there's a thing about capturing that overall sound like that. You know in the old days, those guys were singing — Jimmy Rushing and those guys were singing with no microphones and just carrying over the whole band. Because there were no mics on stage.

MR: Well that's why when I listen to the Basie, they call it the All American Rhythm Section, it just sounds like one entity. Because they, I don't know if they were so totally conscious of balancing their own volume but they surely did. And I had the experience once, on multiple, this one night after the other at a festival I heard the L.A. Juggernaut Big Band, Frankie Capp and Nat Pierce. And they had mics all over the place and it blew your head off. The next night the Count Basie Orchestra led by Grover Mitchell at the time, no

Frank Foster. At any rate they had like three mics on stage. And it was so much better. The band was in control rather than —

SB: And they mixed themselves. When studio players, when I was playing sessions, and we would go out to play gigs with some artist or something, they'd pay to have us come out with them. We could mix ourselves from stage. We were so used to knowing what we sounded like in our headphones in the studio, once we were on the stage we knew exactly — we had our own levels set. They put the mics up but there was not a lot of mixing going on at the console out front. We mixed ourselves. Of course those guys, these are Basie's, or any of those rhythm sections, they mix themselves. Even Jimmie Lunceford, Chick Webb and those guys, I can only imagine. In those little clubs? You know an 18-piece band and those are not big clubs, like on 52nd Street in New York. But can you imagine that big band but everybody knows it was perfect. The sound — John Hammond talked about, it was like you were hearing a record off that stage from one of the clubs on 52nd Street. And it's just like I say, you've got 200 tracks if you want to use them it's not going to make it a better record. If you had 25 mics on stage, or more now, of course that's the way it's done now. But again, going back to your original question, "Spirituals to Swing" I'll just say it would not have been better with more mics. It wouldn't have been better with today's recording techniques. It's just the way those guys played. And they did mix themselves. And the other thing, I remember Mel Powell, I was talking about, starting with Goodman after Teddy Wilson, he told me, it was a great expression. He said "Our instruments never got cold." Because they would play radio shows in the mornings, they'd play matinees doing something, they'd play a dance or a concert, and then a dance, and then when they're done with that at twelve or one, they all headed to Harlem to sit in and jam. So they played 16, 17 hours a day or more. And that was a great expression I'll never forget, "Our instruments never got cold." So yeah, the All American Rhythm Section, you can only imagine how much they played. It's not just they played a gig each night. They played all the time. So they were like one instrument, those bands, the rhythm sections. The brass section, the woodwinds, they were like one — here's one instrument, here's one instrument, here's one instrument. The rhythm section, the brass, and the woodwinds.

MR: Were those the good old days?

SB: Well certainly, I wish I'd of lived in those times. Really, I mean I got to see the last of the big bands when I first started doing orchestra dates in L.A. String dates, orchestra dates, 60 pieces. A lot of the horn players were from that era, the big band era. So I got to hear the stories. Larry Welk told me great stories. The guy said his father had in the horns were big band guys, and they'd take breaks and Lawrence Welk would go to his dressing room and eat a chicken salad sandwich, they were at the bar down the street. And Larry

was the band boy, running errands for them. So he knew all the stories from these guys. They'd all played with the big bands. They'd put on their suits and do the Lawrence Welk Show. But these guys could swing if they really wanted to, or were allowed to. But I knew a lot of the big band guys. The first time I did the Tonight Show when Johnny Carson was still the host, I mean Severinsen played with Tommy Dorsey, those guys were all, mostly big band alumni. And you heard all the stories, and they were obviously good old days. But when I came along it was still good old days because those guys were still around playing orchestra dates, like I say, in L.A. They were the Hollywood film scores on the big sound stages. Those were a lot of the horn players from the 40s. And so I still got to experience that. And Les Brown still had his band when I was out in L.A. and I went to the Palladium. I somehow met his granddaughter or somebody. Anyway and he still had — oh who was the male singer with Les Brown and the Band of Renown — Butch Dunn — he was still singing with Les Brown and the Band of Renown. And I went to see them at the Palladium where all the big bands played. That was the last of the big bands, actually the last of the big band was Severinsen's band on the Tonight Show.

MR: Yeah. Did you ever hear those fellas complain or comment about transition from swing to rock & roll?

SB: It was more, they talked and it brings to mind when you say that, it wasn't so much swing, the big bands, to rock & roll, it was swing music, the war, the Glenn Miller Army Air Force Band, which was like the hand picked — the best of every big band Glenn Miller got. But when the war was over nobody could afford the big bands hardly anymore. What they talked more about was when bop came in. That — I never heard them say anything about rock & roll, but when bop came in — Dizzy Gillespie, Charlie Parker, that was a different world from the world they played. And that's the comments I heard more. Never about rock & roll. Because they played on, sometimes they would use sax sections on rock & roll records. It was studio work for those guys. But they weren't called for bop records.

MR: That's true. I never thought of it that way, from an employment standpoint. I mean you knew the band shrunk and, but yeah, especially the saxophone players, a lot of them found work in the rock & roll.

SB: Oh brass and woodwinds. Well especially in Hollywood for the film scores, and when I was producing big pop records like Dionne Warwick and things like that. I'd cut the tracks wherever — Nashville, and back then it would be Atlanta or Nashville, or in L.A., but then you do your what they call your sweetening dates. And you'd go in and you'd have the big — well my string sections were usually 12 – 4 – 4 and 2. 12 violins, 4 violas, four celli, and 2 string basses. And if we had the budget I'd use like 18 violins and scaled in, but we always, we'd do 12 – 4 — 4 and 2 and double it. So it was like a huge

string section. But then we'd have — if it was an orchestra date, not just a string date we would call it, we'd have just the strings and this woman named Gayle Levant on the harp, doing the glissandos and all that stuff. And then the brass section and the woodwind section. I think the biggest sections I worked with was 65 pieces. And you talk about — you don't show stress but when you've got 65 people sitting out there on the clock, you better be starting on time, because you've got to get your three or four songs in that three hour session or they're off to the next session, or if God forbid you went into overtime, because with 60 pieces. So I had my arranger, my conductor, me, I mean we all had our phones on at the podium, I mean plus you can imagine how many mics that took to set up. We'd start setting up at six in the morning for a nine or ten o'clock session. So you don't want to be sitting there waiting for engineers to finish setting up microphones with 65 people looking at you.

MR: And you hope the fire alarm doesn't go off like it did today.

SB: I've had some things happen. I had a roof collapse in a control room one time with — water on the roof came crashing in and I dived under the console. My engineer dived over the tape machine. I've never had a fire alarm go off, but I'll tell you one thing that happened. There was a great arranger in L.A. named Gene Page. And I'm sitting there, I think, usually our sessions would be 10-1, 2-5, 6-9, and if you went late, 10 to 1 in the morning, but then you're into an hour overtime, after midnight. So you usually did your three sessions a day. I had a ten o'clock date in L.A. It was a big string date. There was a man named Sid Sharp who was the concertmaster, and the second was always a fella named Jimmy Getzoff. And there Jimmy and Sid's right in front of me. And they're looking at the clock, and I'm looking at my watch. No Gene Page. No charts.

MR: No music.

SB: No charts.

MR: Oh no.

SB: So finally it was like five 'til. And Sid Sharp looks at me and said, "Who's doing the arrangements?" I said, "Gene Page." And he rolled his eyes.

MR: Oh he gave the look, oh.

SB: And he said, "Oh my God," he said, "we did a Manilow session and he was like an hour late last week." So then you feel your stomach, you know. You don't show it, but. Finally the door flew open right at like one minute 'til. And literally he comes in with the charts trailing out behind him. It was like out of a movie. And you know scramble to get the charts laid out. And we started maybe seven minutes late. And we got it all in. But of course in the rundown everybody, you all have your scores in front of you. The conductor, my arranger and me. And as they run it down you just circle mistakes. Because there's always mistakes on a big chart, with a big section like that. And as it's

being rundown you're "Bar 64" you know, and you go back and say okay. Then my arranger would say, "Change that E to E flat," you know you correct. It has to be done like that. And then you do your take. And then — I shouldn't say this but it's way back now, but I'd do a take, I'd call it a rundown, with the string section. I'd say, "Let's do a rundown," after we got our mistakes corrected. Let's run it down one more time to be sure. I'd record it. And okay, "Let's do the take now." We'd do the take. They knew what I was doing. They knew I was getting a double out of them. Because you have to pay for a double.

MR: I didn't know that.

SB: Yeah. It's called a double and it's on the contract. It's a double, and it's all listed. So they knew what I was doing but they liked me enough, and I gave them enough work that they weren't busting me — "Wait a minute, we know what you're" — they knew exactly what I was doing. Because everybody was doing it. So instead of having a 12 — 4 — 4 — and 2 section, now you have a 24 — 8 — 8 and 4 section.

MR: Oh you were recording them over themselves.

SB: I didn't play it back to them.

MR: I see what you were doing.

SB: You'd do your first rundown and correct your mistakes. Then okay, now that we've got our mistakes corrected, let me do another rundown. [whispers] Roll the tape. And the tape would be rolling. And they'd do the part. Sounds great. Let's do our — take one. We wouldn't play the first rundown back so they weren't hearing that in the phones. Great — next song.

MR: Right.

SB: Same routine for the next song. Correct the mistakes, rundown, roll the tape. And then it ended up, really, it was a double but we weren't paying for a double. Now if I had an unlimited budget I was very open. Okay. We would actually do triples sometimes. But you'd pay for every pass — pass, every recording.

MR: I thought that whatever you could do in three hours that you could do.

SB: Nope. There's a section on the contracts, you know, there's the first take or whatever you want to call it, and then if it was a double, there's another column. If there was a step out, a solo, that was another column. If Sweets was going to step out and do a obligato that's a separate section. A solo, you were paid extra for that too. So it wasn't everything you could get in three hours there's your session. There was all those little categories. And there was definitely a thing for solos, step outs they called it. So if a sax stepped out — I'm talking about during the take, if he stepped in and did a solo, or Sweets did a solo or whoever, there's another column for that. You get paid extra for that, each guy who took a solo.

MR: Who is paying that bill, the record company?

SB: Um hum.

MR: Yeah. And you have to be very cognizant of all that.

SB: Oh my God, yeah. I had to do the budget.

MR: You had to do the budget.

SB: Yeah. Ahead of time. If you had it, back in those days if you had $150,000 budget you had to figure out not only what the musicians were going to cost, not just the rhythm section but the string date, orchestra date, travel, hotels for the artists, for me. All that had to be — I mean even down to me catering the meals for the rhythm section. Everything. It was an extens — I had a whole pages of sheets that I would fill in for each album I was doing. No I had to do the budget and if it was a hundred grand, a hundred and fifty grand, two hundred grand, you'd be surprised how quick that could go back in those days.

MR: Was your fee in that?

SB: No.

MR: That was separate.

SB: No. I was paid my production fee, and I was paid my royalty points. That was separate.

MR: Okay, I don't know if you can answer this question. It's fill in the blanks.

SB: I'll try.

MR: A hit song needs blank.

SB: A great song.

MR: A hit song means a great song.

SB: Oh I thought you meant a hit record.

MR: A hit record needs —

SB: A great song.

MR: Okay. Does it need anything else?

SB: Great musicians. Well, in my time. First of all there is an old expression in Nashville, "It all starts with the song." As I've said ad nauseam, I can have the best musicians in the world, the best engineer, the best artist, but if it's a mediocre song it's going to be a mediocre record. That's held true throughout my career. I don't know that it holds true now. But if you don't have a great song, you don't have a hit record, you don't have a great record. Everything else could be the best in the world. If it's a lousy song it's going to be a lousy record.

MR: Yesterday in your film compilation, I don't know if Andrew Young said this or if you inserted this. But I believe it was like, "The music comes first and the lyrics" —

SB: That was Andrew Young. That's when he made the statement about you could say that music was more successful than the courts in integrating society. He said people would be singing along with it, like the Impressions he was talking about, Curtis Mayfield and

the Impressions. He said and it's only until later you realize what you're singing, the lyric, and what you're singing about. You're singing along and then later, whoa. You know, "People get ready there's a train" — we're talking about the movement, the Civil Rights Movement here. Yeah. That was Andrew Young.

MR: Yeah. That's an astute comment. I want to talk about the blues.

SB: No more fill in the blanks?

MR: I'll think of some. I always feel there's something — not always — but often times when I read about the blues the main thrust of what people write about is the emotion and the social conditions that gave rise to that music. And there's pretty short shrift given to the 12-bar musical form of the blues. And what reminded me of it was yesterday when you were at the beginning of your film and we were talking about rockabilly and rock & roll, all those songs were 12-bar blues.

SB: 12-bar blues. Yeah.

MR: And I don't know if it's just because it's too much a technical musical thing, but I don't think the 12-bar blues gets the recognition it should as this incredible, precise musical form that can be used in so many different ways.

SB: Well I obviously began my life, my career, playing basically 12-bar blues, whether it was rhythm & blues, blues, soul music in the early days, rhythm & blues/soul music, country. And basically, you're talking about 12-bar manuscripts. Clapton has, there's a great thing on Clapton, it's called *Life in Twelve Bars*. And that sums it up, doesn't it? Now of course things got way more sophisticated. But that's, to me — I'm not the guy who said oh that's what it was, it was all based on 12-bar blues. I'm not the first person to say that. But it is. And you're right, it is sold short, looked down on. But it shouldn't be. Because it's the basis for so much of it, so much music. Things got much, as you know, jazz got more sophisticated. Swing bands got more sophisticated. But if you go back to the early days of blues, rock & roll, rhythm & blues, soul music, and it's basically still a form of 12-bar blues I think. I mean don't you?

MR: Yes I do. And that's sort of why I wanted your opinion on it. It's so elastic. It's like a chameleon almost you know.

SB: That's a perfect way to put it, yeah.

MR: Whatever you want it to be you can do with it. Yeah. Is there an American music?

SB: Well this is my opinion. Country music is American music. It was like the poor white man's blues. Blues I think is an American art form. Jazz is an American art form. And bluegrass is an American art form. Now it's played all over — all these genres, these different forms of music are played all over the world. But where did it start? Louis Armstrong. Bill Monroe. Hank Williams, and others in the country. I mean those are American art forms, in my opinion.

MR: Good answer. I'm not sure I can verbalize this question, but sometimes I read sociologists writing about music and then you read musicians talking about where their music came from. And a lot of times they're not sort of on the same page. I wonder how much you feel the social conditions that musicians grow up in affects their musicianship.

SB: Good question. Well if you look at the greats, the legends, they certainly didn't come from affluent background. Louis Armstrong certainly didn't. Hank Williams certainly didn't. I think you go to any great legendary musician and it usually comes — I mean Dolly, very humble backgrounds. You're talking about I mean really humble backgrounds, and a lot of these people, whether it's country, blues, jazz, rock & roll, Elvis certainly didn't come from an affluent background. He was influenced by Chuck Berry and Fats Domino and Little Richard. They certainly didn't come from affluent backgrounds nor did James Brown. So I think it has a huge impact on the musician coming up from humble backgrounds. But then again, look at the person who really had such an impact on society, John Hammond, did come from an affluent background but he was not a musician. But he recognized good musicians and had great ears, but came from a very affluent background. That's why he was able to pay for those early records. But the musicians — I can't say there's no musician I've ever met who didn't come from a wealthy family, maybe, but we never talked about it. But most of us grew up the same way — you know lower middle class, middle class, listening to a lot of the same music, struggling, especially studio guys I knew from everywhere. I always likened it to this mob of people trying to get through a keyhole to be a studio musician, and just a few at a time can slip through. Everybody wanted to do it. I always said, I was just talking about this yesterday, that most of the time when you go out and see somebody on the road playing concerts, that's not the people that played on the record. It's a road band. Everybody out on the road wants to be a studio musician, or at least used to be. They all wanted to be in the studio. They did this hoping that it was going to lead to that. And I always likened it to a mob trying to get through a keyhole. And we all grew up, and we came from everywhere, just like actors and actresses that flocked to Hollywood. We went to music centers, whether it was Nashville, Memphis, Muscle Shoals, New York, L.A. Detroit, Philadelphia. We came from everywhere and found each other. And we were let in through the keyhole. And we all had similar backgrounds. Some of the guys I know, like Hungate, we spoke about David Hungate earlier, North Texas State, that great One O'clock Jump Jazz Band, he could read everything, but his father was a judge up in Indiana. But David, believe me, once he got out of North Texas State and went to L.A., he had to work his way up the ranks. I mean Toto was one thing, but they were all studio, young studio guys, Porcaro and Hungate and all those guys. They all had to compete and prove themselves, like all of us did. And you have to do the same thing as a producer. At

least this is the way it used to be. Now, somebody told me today, one of the students said something to me about — I was talking about the recording and how it used to be, the studios. A student said, "Yeah but it might be more democratized now because everybody can make a record." And I said, "You're right. Everybody who has a laptop can put on garage band and make a record. But — it is democratized, but I said, "To me, to my ears, in my experience, it sounds like somebody sitting down with their computer making a record. It's not the same. We all were into high fidelity. George Massenburg was talking — "I want the records to be hi fi." We wanted our stuff to sound hi fi. Our instruments, the records that I was producing them, it was like we wanted to be there. And now, I keep talking about this. Caroline, my wife, hears this all the time about the bar keeps getting lower and lower and lower. Now that's an old guy talking, in retrosp — you know I don't want to be one of the old guys talking about well in my day — but you know once you had to be, to do what we did you had to be great as a player or as a producer or as a songwriter or as an engineer. Or you didn't get work the next week.

MR: Is it true that the majority of the pop icons never went to music school? They were self-taught musicians who learned either with mentors or just through doing it.

SB: When you're talking about pop icons, you're talking about the legendary singers or somebody like that.

MR: Yes.

SB: I think so. I don't know any singer I ever worked with — well no, I can tell you a couple. When I produced Dionne Warwick's albums for Clive Davis, Dionne had gone, she was a a music teacher. And we were doing a session one day, it was a Michael McDonald song that must have had dozens of chord changes in it and oh, it was fast. I can't even remember the name of the song. And I had the best guys. And the guitarist that day was Larry Byron from Muscle Shoals. Larry had played with Steppenwolf at one time, and then went back to Muscle Shoals and was one of the best studio guitarists. Larry had sketched up a chart that — we did it together. And anyway, in the middle of the song, with dozens of chord changes going a mile a minute, Dionne in the mic said, "Wait a minute, wait a minute, wait a minute." "What?" She said, "There's a wrong chord in there." So we all gathered around the piano with the charts and she says, "Right there." Because right before we put the charts down on the piano I leaned over to Larry and I said, "How sure are you about the chart?" He said, "I'd bet my life on it." And anyway, in this fast, uptempo thing with dozens of chord changes, she heard, there was actually like — I don't know I'm just going to make this chord up, an E flat nine flat seven. Anyway, there was one note in the chord that was a half a step off in our chart. And she heard it. So that kind of put you on your toes. So she picked that, and it was not B.S., she heard it and we all, when she pointed it out, there's the wrong chord. And we put it on

Michael McDonald's demo and there it was. One note in a chord was a half a step off. You know, it was supposed to be — instead of a seven it was supposed to be a flat seven or a major seven — some note was a half a step off. So there is an example of somebody who did go to school. That's the only singer I can think of off the top of my head, that went to school, and subsequently she took us to school that day. But most — I can't think of any other singers who were schooled like that. Maybe some jazz singers or something like that. Now there were musicians, I taught myself to read, I taught myself theory. But guys like Hungate studied at North Texas State, and there were other guys who'd studied. Matt Rawlings the keyboard player I mentioned earlier, he went to Berklee for a couple of years then he dropped out and went to Nashville and he took off. He's on the road right now with Alison Krauss. We just saw Alison and Matt and the guys a few weeks ago. So when he hit town he could read flypaper as we say, Hungate could read flypaper. Most of the guys could. You had to. But in the south too we had number charts to contend with. Well not to contend with, that's what I learned, in other words writing the charts in numbers rather than manuscript paper. And I think I've shown you some examples of that. I showed some students today in that jazz class. And they were wanting to take pictures of one of the number charts because it looks like an algebra formula when you look at the page. And I can remember specifically one time, it was on a Melissa Manchester Christmas album and I had Eddie Gomez flying to Nashville from New York, and Lewis Nash on drums, and I put out the number charts, for things like "White Christmas," "I'll be Home For" — I don't know, you know the different standards. And Eddie looked at the — now of course Eddie Gomez can play, and he looked at the chart and he said, "What the hell is that?" And I said, "Well it's a number chart" but I said, "just look at it as one is the root. And he looked at it for a minute and he said, "Well I get it," he said, "but I don't need to do an exercise in math." He said, "Let me just write my own chart out." And he wrote his own chart out. He didn't use the number chart. And it would be the same, if I went to L.A. I always took a number chart but I also took a manuscript chart. And in New York I always took a manuscript chart. Because of course they pick up on it right away. Well I get it but I don't want to have to be thinking flat seven and you know six minor and all that kind of stuff.

MR: That's funny, if you took the written notes to Nashville and they convert it to the number chart.

SB: Well we do it by ear. You know you listen to the demo and I can remember going to play on sessions in Muscle Shoals and Nashville and Atlanta, and they wouldn't even come in with the chart, even a number chart. They'd just play you the demo and you sat there with your own paper making your own chart. And you'd write your numbers up. And so like I

said to the class today, there are a number of guys who do have perfect pitch, but everybody had to have perfect relative pitch to be a good studio musician.

MR: I see.

SB: You had to have perfect relative pitch. If you hear the note, then you know the next note is a 4 or a 6 minor or whatever. You'd write your own charts out. I never did that with the players when I produced. I always did the charts ahead of time with one of my musicians, usually the piano player or the guitar player on whichever session it was. I'd do the charts — I came with them printed up, put them out in the studio. In the control room, "Here's your chart, here's the demo, follow the chart." And I'd put in little notations like, "The fills on this verse piano." I'd just write it above, just piano. That meant on that verse the piano fills. Next verse it might be, I don't know, somebody else fills.

MR: Yeah, you don't want to fill on a fill.

SB: No, no, no. And everybody knows to stay out of everybody's way anyway. But I would come in with the number charts in Nashville, and I'd run the demo, play the demo, or sit there with the guitar and play it with whoever is singing, and everybody makes their notes in the chart, where they're filling. I'd write down and they'd put little notes to themselves — go out to the studio, do a rundown, and I'd always record that. Because sometimes it would be the rundown, and if the chart was right, a lot of times that was the take. Then I'd do a rundown, take one, take two, maybe take three. If it went past that I'd say something's wrong with the chart. Put it away, I'll look at it during the lunch break. Next song.

MR: Move on.

SB: But mostly we got it either on the rundown or take one or take two.

MR: What would get you back into the studio now as a producer?

SB: It would have to be an old friend wanting me to do something with them again. Because if it was a new artist now, honestly I wouldn't know what to do — I mean I'd know what to do musically but I wouldn't know what to do because the structure, the business has changed so dramatically since 2000, the year 2000. Particularly. I look at that as the watershed year because that's when the kids came out with Napster and people were downloading music and the income just — they're talking about now how streaming has lifted up the record companies, but I still get my statements. And it's like for a stream I'm looking at .0002 cents, you know? That type of thing. Whereas it used to be eight dollars and something from this, that and the other. The royalties I make now are still from the old records, because the new stuff that's streamed — I just read an article talking about how streaming has lifted the record industry back up, but nobody hardly buys physical product anymore. There's almost as much vinyl sold now as there are CDs because that's come back. But compared to — most of it's streamed. And first of all, I don't like the

sound of streamed music because of the compression that's necessary. I don't care for the way records are made in the most part. One of the students was asking me during the fire drill up here, how records are made. I said, "Well you know I know all the great players that are still around, but they rarely are called in to do live sessions anymore. The way it's done mostly now, with the exception of jazz and bluegrass and classical, a producer and his artist lay down a drum loop and maybe an acoustic guitar or a piano. They send it to Eddie Bayer's, my longtime friend and drummer. They send it to Eddie, he puts down his part in his own studio. Then it goes back up to a dropbox, iCloud, whatever. Then Michael Rhodes the bass player gets it and adds his part. Back up. Then it goes to whoever, Matt Rawlings to add piano. They hardly ever see each other in the studio anymore. And the magic was out on the floor what happened. Here's your chart. But then there's that magic, that give and take. Hey what about this? What about this little lick right here? What about this? And that's the magic. Doing records like this, emailing them to each other or whatever, you don't get that interaction. And the guys tell me that. They are seldom called into a session anymore where they're all there. Because this is the way it's done. And I said unfortunately to me that's the way the records sound. I started hearing it oh way back. I called it homogenization. Because they were all mixed exactly the same, they tried to get the loudest level they could for radio at that time, and then it was like they'd have to be compressed tremendously to be streamed and kids listen in the earbuds. It's not the full sonic spectrum anymore in those records. Now again I'm sure somebody will look at this and it's just some old guy talking about the way it used to be. I'm not bitter about it, I got to do it at the right time. We all said how lucky we were. It was the best of those old guys that we got to learn from. Not just the horn players and the string players but the great old rhythm sections like the Wrecking Crew in L.A. or the Funk Brothers in Detroit. We got to learn from them and kind of take the baton through our period. And then it just started drifting away after our era. So I'm not bitter about it. I'm grateful that I did it when I did it.

MR: Well I'm grateful you did it.

SB: So what it would take for me to get back, it'd have to be somebody that I worked with. "Hey, let's get together, what do you think, and do it like the old days. Get the guys and the gals and do it like we used to do it." I would do that. But to take a new artist from scratch like I used to do, sign an artist to Columbia or Vanguard and then try to work it through this maze that exists now to try to get stuff streamed. And labels, when I was talking about $100,000, $150,000, $200,000 budgets — that doesn't exist anymore. Artist development doesn't exist anymore in record companies. You pretty much have to go in with the finished product and a bankroll yourself to really have a record deal anymore. And most people, if you look, the major labels, that was your goal, a major label:

Columbia, RCA, Capitol. Now it's like everybody has their own label practically. Very few you see that are really signed, and if they are they've gone through this ridiculous process that I don't want to go through anymore.

MR: Well if you find that old friend and do it, I want to be invited so I can watch.

SB: Believe me — 'cause there's nothing like it, when it comes live at you off the floor.

MR: Well I enjoyed our second conversation.

SB: Maybe we'll have a third.

MR: Maybe we'll have a third. Maybe we'll do like *Rambo Part Six* doing the sixth movie or something.

SB: I think I'd come up with another analogy. Thanks Monk. You're great man, great questions.

MR: All right.

SB: Great insight. Now remember you're your own cameraman.